Agonizing over language, I realize, is a standard item on the job chart of a central bank governor. In his memoirs, *The Courage to Act*, Bernanke writes: 'We sweated every word. Should I say that additional rate cuts "may be necessary" or "may *well* be necessary"? Should I say that we stood ready to take "*substantive* additional action" or "*meaningful* additional action"? The absurdity of our discussion did not escape us, but we had learned through bitter experience that a single word often mattered.'

Policy Dissemination

The pre-policy drill also includes a briefing session for the governor by the senior management on probable questions in the media conference following the policy. Even though the media conference is scheduled in the context of the policy, the engagement is not restricted to monetary policy. There has for long been a tacit agreement between the Reserve Bank and its media interlocutors that the entire domain of the central bank's functions would be par for the course. Our preparation too would accordingly cover a wide canvas, with senior staff stretching their imagination to think of possible questions and tips on how responses might be nuanced. These prep meetings would be conversational and free-flowing, far from the 'murder boards' of the American political and corporate scene where the staff pose as the media and the CEO practises his answers.

The media build-up on the policy starts a week before and reaches fever pitch by the announcement date. What with proliferation of business channels, there would be dozens of commentators on air talking about what the Reserve Bank *should* do and what it *would* do. As a matter of habit, I am not much of a TV person; I usually got my inputs from the print media but there would be enough speculation there as well, although less dramatic than that on TV. Polls of economists and analysts on the Reserve Bank's policy stance are now common fare. Some friends would ask me if all the speculation in the media prior to the policy review influenced my decision. I don't believe it has, but of course, by definition, I cannot speak for any unconscious osmosis of ideas.